

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

“There is precious treasure and oil in the dwelling of the wise, but a foolish man swallows it up.”

It's hard to understand why so many parents who have had bitter experiences with debt, including divorce, fail to teach their children how to avoid it. In reality, any parent can discourage debt simply by encouraging saving. After all, we need “things” (kids do too) and must either save or borrow to get them.

While teaching a group of seminary students on the biblical principles of managing money, I found myself counseling virtually every free minute. These were students about to graduate into careers as pastors and missionaries who were deep in debt. Most had student loans that stretched back seven and eight years. Others had credit card debts, car loans, bank loans, and family loans. Without realizing it, most of these potential Christian leaders had doomed their careers and marriages through excessive borrowing. Few churches would be able to pay salaries sufficient to meet their needs and virtually no mission groups could.

A young man named Jeremy shared that his father had started him saving at a very early age and promised to match his saving dollar-for-dollar if he wouldn't touch it for 10 years. He worked the normal kids' jobs: a paper route, summer work, washing cars, et cetera. He had used some of his savings to purchase a pressure cleaner for sidewalks while in high school and started going door-to-door, cleaning driveways and sidewalks. After that, he was self-employed.

By the time he started college, he owned a car and had over \$20,000 in savings. He supplemented his savings by working at his business during vacations and summers. His father paid for one half of his college expenses and he paid the other half.

When he graduated from college and entered seminary, he sold his cleaning business for \$25,000 and used \$5,000 to purchase a parking lot striping machine. So he entered seminary debt-free and with \$20,000 in savings. He again supplemented his savings by painting stripes on small parking lots. That business grew to where he employed four other stu-